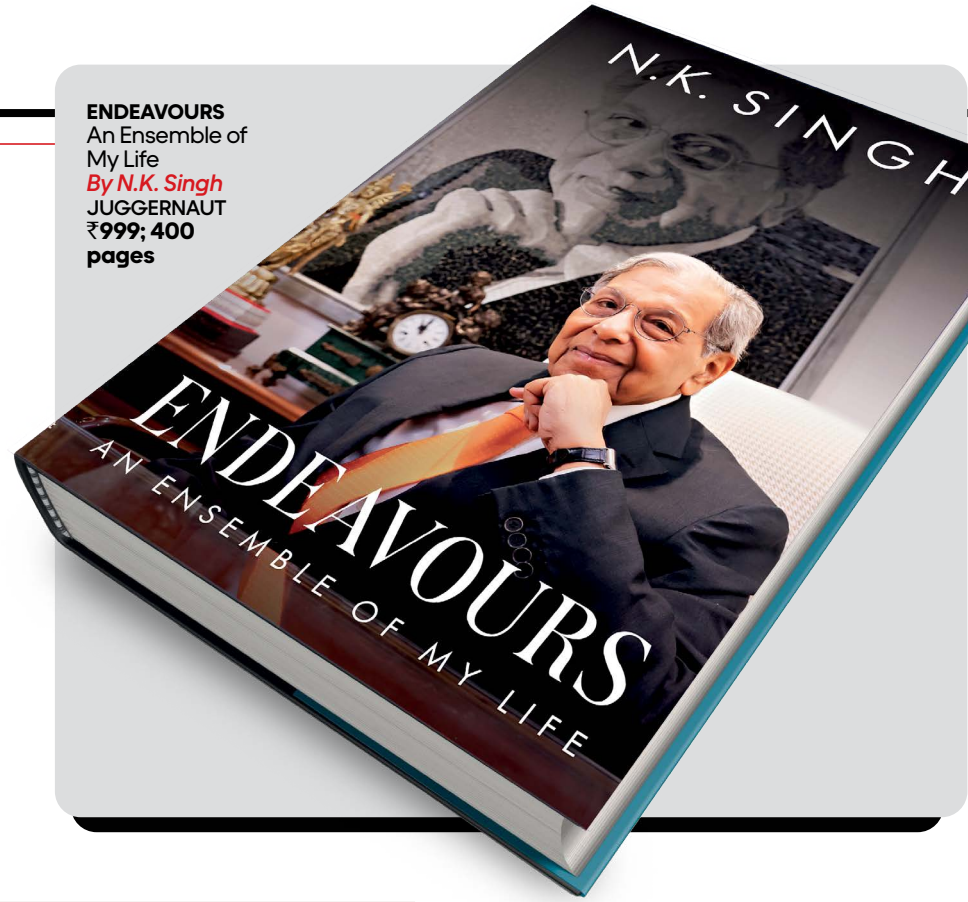



**ENDEAVOURS**
An Ensemble of My Life
*By N.K. Singh*
JUGGERNAUT
**₹999; 400 pages**

What is a good life? Some people define it through their professional accomplishments and the status in society that it brings. Wiser people know that a good life has many dimensions that enrich us, sustain us through challenges and provide joy and meaning. N.K. Singh's latest book *Endeavours: An Ensemble of My Life* shows us those important other dimensions and how vital they are for one of the most prominent policymakers and public servants in India today.

The book is written not as a traditional chronological recounting of the various senior roles Singh held throughout his distinguished career, but as a rich tapestry of personal passions. The book offers a masterclass in what it means to lead a deeply textured and full life. For readers of INDIA TODAY, Singh's reflections serve as a timely reminder that a flourishing society relies just as much on the cultivation of our human spirit, our curiosity and our shared cultural memory as it does on economic well-being.

**WHAT MAKES THIS BOOK SO UTTERLY COMPELLING IS ITS CENTRAL METAPHOR: A FULFILLING LIFE IS AN ENSEMBLE, NOT A SINGLE PERFORMANCE BUT MANY THINGS COMBINED**

## The Life as an Ensemble

Singh describes his diverse interests not as casual hobbies or mere distractions from his demanding career, but as "endeavours"—a word that beautifully captures sustained commitment, humility and the understanding that mastery is a lifelong journey rather than a destination. It is not the achievement that matters most, but the trying.

Across seven absorbing chapters, he invites us into the private realms that have nourished his public life: tending to a magnificent rose garden inherited from his father, capturing the silent poetry of Japan through photography, safeguarding the timeless traditions of Indian classical music, engaging with the fine arts and homoeopathy, and traversing a transforming world through decades of global diplomacy.

To read Singh's reflections on his life is to be reminded of another great intellectual and public servant: John Maynard Keynes. Keynes famously believed that economics was merely a toolkit for achieving the good life, maintaining that true fulfilment required a rich engagement with art, literature, philosophy and human relationships. Although widely known for his intellectual contributions to economics, his critical role in creating the World Bank and the IMF after World War II and his contributions to many key policy questions, Keynes also created the Arts Council, arguing that, in a civilised society, public funding of the arts was essential. Like Keynes, Singh demonstrates that public service is never compromised by cultivating outside passions; rather, it is deeply enriched by them.

What makes this book so utterly compelling is its central metaphor: a fulfilling life is an ensemble (derived from the French word for "together"), not a single performance but many things combined. Just as an orchestra relies on the harmonious interplay of diverse instruments, a well-lived life draws its richness from the synthesis of our professional duties, our family relationships, our aesthetic responses to beauty, and our intellectual curiosities and personal passions.

## Roots, Growth and Generational Memory

Among the most moving sections of the book are Singh's reflections on his early life in Bihar and his deep connection to the land and appreciation for nature. When he eventually assumed stewardship of his father's sprawling garden—growing it into a sanctuary of some 2,500 plants and over 300 rose